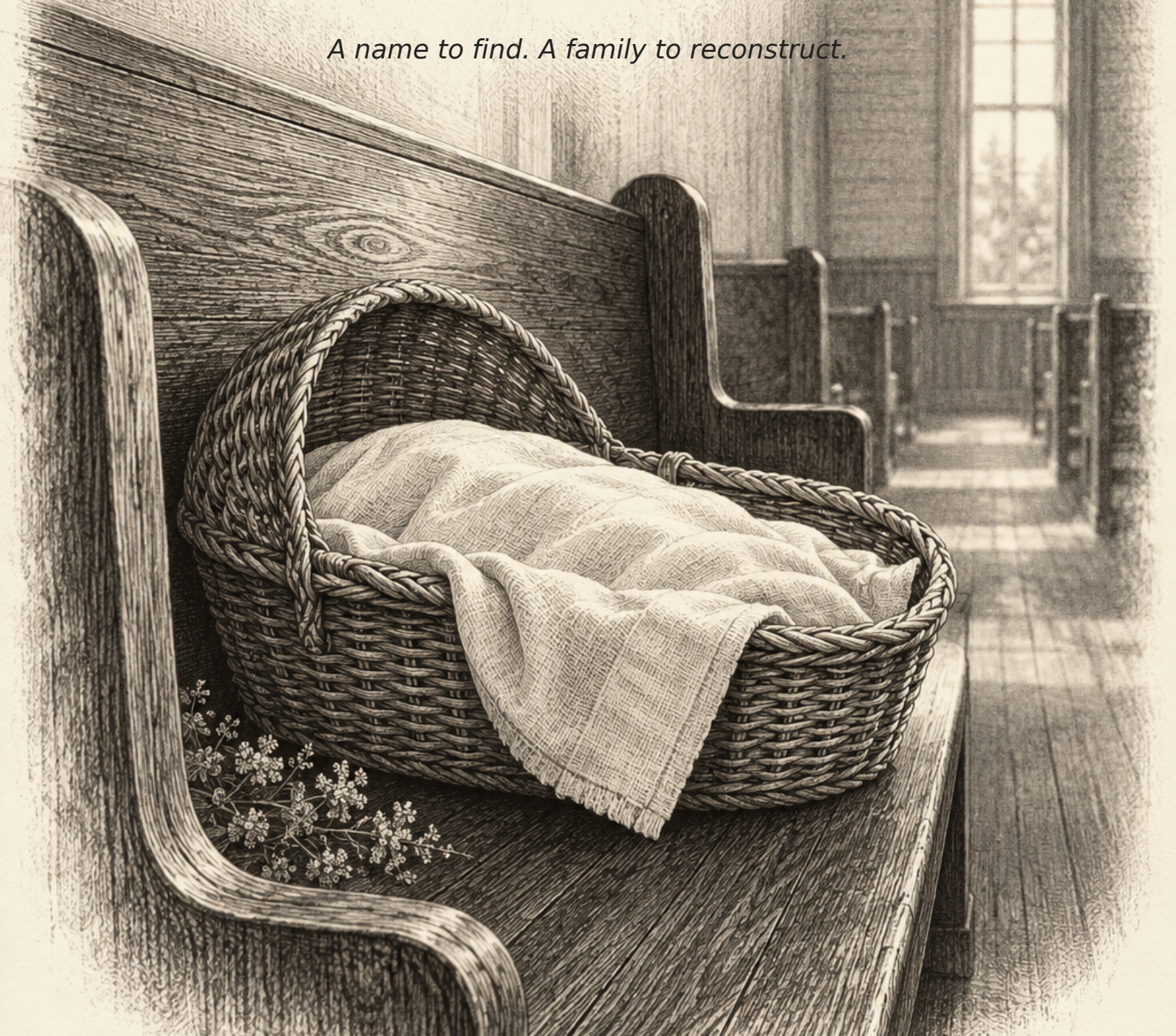


Baby in a Basket

A name to find. A family to reconstruct.



READ FIRST

Read the people. Test the papers.

Print the Player PDF in full. This edition contains 36 pages, including its cover and interleaved story. Use US Letter, portrait, actual size / 100%; on A4, use Fit. Grayscale is sufficient. Single-sided lets you spread the records out; duplex uses the long edge. Keep the separate hints and sealed solution away from the player stack.

Follow the printed archive folios. Existing page references mean the numbers labeled ARCHIVE in the footers, which remain stable. New story leaves use S0-S3. They make the PDF positions different from the archive numbers. Use the bookmarks or clickable catalog to find a page on screen.

Begin with the opening scene and brief. Read BB01-BB03 and choose your next record through archive folios 8-9. Each later scene names the records to read first. In a nonlinear search, return to that scene after you have examined its records; scene order does not prove a connection.

Let the records carry the proof. The new scenes dramatize the people around these papers. They are fictional narrative, not additional archival exhibits. A character can be mistaken. Names, dates, parents, addresses, source references, and the supplied rules establish the case; sympathy does not.

Make your case. Use archive folios 27-32. Cite exhibit codes and exact fields, test alternatives, and leave unsupported matters open. Everyone investigates; no host, internet, cutting, or outside research is required. Use hints only when needed; open the solution after answering all final questions.

The four birth identities are the complete candidate set. The sealed letter supplies private confirmation only after you commit.

THE STORY CONTINUES

The question before the wedding

Before the opening brief / Mabel's family story

Edith had always been able to tell the story of the basket. The church, the little girl, the home waiting for her. When Mabel was small, the telling ended with Edith drawing her close. It was a good ending for a child who wanted to be certain she belonged.

As a grown woman preparing to enter her name in another register, Mabel discovered that the same ending could close a door.

"What am I to put?" she asked.

Edith looked at the paper. "Sutton. You've always been Sutton."

"I know my name. I mean before."

Thomas kept his eyes on the table. He could repair a thing with a split in it. He could not make this question fit neatly beside the life they had given her.

Edith reached to straighten Mabel's sleeve. Mabel let her. She loved that hand. She also wanted it to stop answering questions nobody had asked.

"We don't have those names," Edith said.

"Then I want to look."

For a moment Edith's face made Mabel feel as though she had announced she was leaving them. The unfairness of that feeling brought heat to her eyes. She had not wanted an argument. She had wanted permission not to know something and still need to know it.

"Was there something you lacked here?" Edith asked.

Thomas moved then, drawing a chair out so Mabel could sit. "She asked about the papers."

Edith looked at him, hurt. He did not withdraw the chair.

Mabel sat. "I can be grateful and ask. Can't I?"

The answer took long enough to matter.

Edith put her hand flat on the table. "Yes."

They had no account of the person who carried the basket. The old newspaper did not provide one. Thomas and Edith could tell Mabel how she had come into their care, but their love did not turn that knowledge into a birth record.

Mabel drew the clipping toward her. For the first time she read the estimate of the infant's age as something a doctor had tried to judge, not as the beginning of a story she had to accept whole.

She wanted a name. She was afraid of the reason it had been taken away. Across the table, Edith was afraid that finding it would make Sutton seem smaller. Neither fear could choose the answer. Somewhere in the county's ordinary papers, other children had been entered under other parents' names.

The story she was given

The Sutton family papers

Mabel Ruth Sutton grew up knowing where her family story began: a basket, a church pew, and the couple who took her home.

Thomas and Edith Sutton raised her as their daughter. The name Sutton stayed with her into adulthood. But the story of the basket never supplied the names of the people who had come before them.

Now the papers are in front of you. A household schedule. A newspaper clipping. A marriage entry. Beyond those, the local archive holds birth and death registers and records of other families in the same county.

Name in the starting papers	What you have been told
Mabel Ruth Sutton	The child found in a basket; later raised as the Suttons' daughter.
Thomas Sutton	The man who raised Mabel; a carpenter.
Edith Sutton	The woman who raised Mabel.
Lydia Mercer	Edith's mother; also in the Sutton household.

Your question: Who was Mabel Ruth Sutton before she became the Suttons' daughter, and what family circumstances best explain her arrival at the church?

This is a closed case: the correct birth identity is among the four infant entries in the archive index. The records contain enough evidence to choose the best-supported identity. Private actions may remain uncertain until the sealed family paper is opened.

How to read these papers

A few conventions; no outside research needed.

A HOUSEHOLD IS A SNAPSHOT

A census records people living together on a particular date. A relationship such as daughter, niece, or boarder is the relationship entered in that record. It is evidence to compare, not an automatic guarantee of biological parentage.

DATES MEAN DIFFERENT THINGS

A newspaper publication date is not necessarily the event date. A birth month in an index is less precise than a birth date in a register. Put the actual event dates on your timeline.

MOTHER OF HOW MANY CHILDREN

The census fields for children born and children living refer to children borne by the woman whose row is being recorded. They do not count every child living in her household. A zero is an entry; a dash in these extracts means the field was not copied.

AGES CAN BE IMPERFECT

In these census extracts, 4/12 means four months. An estimated age is a search aid, not an exact birthday. Small disagreements can occur; compare the full name, dates, household, and other records.

AN ABSENCE IS A QUESTION

Someone missing from a later household may have married, moved, entered service, died, or been omitted from an extract. Use a positive record to explain an absence whenever possible.

RECORD WHAT YOU CAN SUPPORT

Write down what a paper says separately from what you think it means. Your final answer should distinguish a supported identity from a private act no public witness has identified.

All people and individual case records are fictional. The exhibits are newly designed period-style facsimiles with selected fields, not authentic archival scans. Handwriting, typefaces, paper wear, punctuation, and page order are not hidden clues.

Sutton household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 15 April 1910

THIRTEENTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Age	Birthplace	Occupation
<i>Sutton, Thomas</i>	<i>Head</i>	<i>42</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	<i>carpenter</i>
<i>Sutton, Edith</i>	<i>Wife</i>	<i>38</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Sutton, Mabel R.</i>	<i>Daughter</i>	<i>10</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Mercer, Lydia</i>	<i>Mother-in-law</i>	<i>62</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-

CIVIL STATE

Thomas: married. Edith: married. Lydia: widowed.

MOTHER OF HOW MANY CHILDREN

Edith Sutton - Number born: 0. Number now living: 0.

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

A clipping from the county paper

Published Monday, 1 October 1900

THE WARREN COUNTY CHRONICLE

LOCAL INTELLIGENCE

INFANT FOUND AT GRACE CHURCH

A female infant was found yesterday morning, September 30, in a basket in a rear pew at Grace Church, before the Sunday services.

The discovery was made by Henry Caldwell, sexton of the church. The name of the person who brought the basket has not been established.

Dr. Samuel Price examined the child and considered her to be about seven months of age and in good health.

The child's parentage was not known at the time of this report.

Local newspaper clipping. The publication title is fictional. No birth surname is supplied in the report.

Bride's entry

Marriage register / 12 June 1919 / Warren County, Ohio

EXTRACT OF FIELDS RELATING TO THE BRIDE

MARRIAGE SOLEMNIZED 12 JUNE 1919

Name entered: Mabel Ruth Sutton

Age: 19

Residence: Warren County, Ohio

Parents who raised her: Thomas Sutton and Edith Sutton

Biological parentage: Not known to the bride.

Mabel Ruth Sutton

Bride's name as entered. This extract reproduces only the bride-related information; the spouse's entry is outside the supplied case.

The register gives the identity Mabel used as an adult. It does not supply a birth surname or a biological parent's name.

THE STORY CONTINUES

What a zero can wound

After BB01-BB03

After the wedding, Mabel brought the marriage extract back to the table with the older papers. Edith's eyes stopped at the census fields. Children born: zero. Children living: zero.

"That isn't what my life was," she said.

Mabel understood the protest before she understood the column. She could supply ten years of contradiction: being dressed, fed, scolded, waited for. She wanted to cross out the zero as fiercely as Edith did.

Then she read the heading again. The count belonged to a particular question. The form had not attempted to measure every kind of motherhood.

"It doesn't say you didn't raise me."

"It looks as if I had no one."

Mabel turned the schedule so they could both see her own line. Daughter. There she was, inside the household and beside the entry that made her ask how she had entered it.

Thomas stood behind Edith's chair. He did not correct either of them. Mabel thought of all the times he had made room for her without making a speech about it. She wanted the investigation to leave that part of their life intact. Wanting was not a method of reading a record.

The marriage extract gave the parents who had raised her. It also left biological parentage unknown. Neither paper erased the other; each had asked for something different.

Edith touched the clipping. "They said she was in good health. I remember being glad of that."

Mabel noticed the change of pronoun. She, the infant. A small person who had existed before Edith could say my daughter. It made the distance visible without explaining it.

"I don't want to lose this family," Mabel said. "I'm trying to find what happened to the other one."

Edith took her hand away from the paper. There was no grand promise in the gesture. She simply stopped holding down the page Mabel wanted to turn.

The entries would need comparison. A census could be mistaken; an adult name could preserve a childhood story without identifying its beginning. The papers offered routes into the question, not a reason to stop loving anyone already in the room.

The archive catalog

Choose a record by name, date, or record type.

Start with BB01-BB03 on pages 5-7. The catalog below locates the additional records. A record's position here does not say whether it will help your theory.

Code	Record	Date	Page
BB04	Birth index / female infants	Jan.-Apr. 1900	10
BB05	Miller household	1900 census	11
BB06	Keane household	1900 census	12
BB07	Reilly household	1900 census	13
BB08	Foster household	1900 census	14
BB09	County death entries	1900	15
BB10	Bennett household	1910 census	16
BB11	Doyle household	1910 census	17
BB12	O'Brien household	1910 census	18
BB13	Reilly household extract	1910 census	19
BB14	Walsh household	1910 census	20
BB15	Hale household	1910 census	21
BB16	Keane household	1910 census	22
BB17	Foster departure notice	1 May 1901	23
BB18	County birth-register extracts	1900 births	24
BB19	Family marriage extracts	1878 and 1884	25
BB20	Grace Church care entry	1 October 1900	26

Name and record finder

Names are search routes, not answers.

Search name	Names recorded	Record / page
Bennett	Charles; Louisa; Arthur; Pearl	BB10 / 16
Caldwell / Price	Henry Caldwell; Dr. Samuel Price	BB02 / 6
Doyle / Flynn	Peter; Mary; Lucy; Edward; Clara	BB11 / 17; BB19 / 25
Foster	Samuel; Jane; Ruth	BB08 / 14; BB09 / 15; BB17 / 23
Hale	Rebecca	BB15 / 21
Keane	William; Anna; Nora	BB06 / 12; BB16 / 22
Mercer / Sutton	Lydia; Thomas; Edith; Mabel	BB01 / 5; BB03 / 7; BB20 / 26
Miller	George; Sarah; Elsie	BB05 / 11; BB09 / 15; BB15 / 21
O'Brien	Jeremiah; Agnes; Francis; Nell	BB12 / 18
Reilly / Flynn	Patrick; Nora; household members	BB07 / 13; BB09 / 15; BB13 / 19; BB19 / 25
Walsh	Edward; Helen; Patrick; Agnes	BB14 / 20

Birth searches: BB04 (index, page 10) and BB18 (fuller entries, page 24). This finder groups the principal household names; someone living in another household may appear under its head's name. Use the records to discover those connections.

Birth index

Warren County, Ohio / female births / January-April 1900

SELECTED INDEX LEAVES

Surname	Given name	Birth month	Register extract
Foster	Ruth	April 1900	BB18
Keane	Nora	January 1900	BB18
Miller	Elsie	March 1900	BB18
Reilly	Mabel	February 1900	BB18

The index points to the fuller birth entries. It supplies no later surname and no record of an infant's movements after registration.

These are the four candidate birth identities included in this closed case. Each has at least one later research route in the catalog.

Miller household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 1 June 1900

TWELFTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Sex	Birt h mo.	Birth year	Age	Civil state	Childre n born	Childre n living
Miller, George	Head	M	Jan	1864	36	M	-	-
Miller, Sarah	Wife	F	May	1868	32	M	-	-
Miller, Elsie	Daughter	F	Mar	1900	2/12	-	-	-

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

M = married. Wd = widowed. Ages under one year are recorded in twelfths of a year. The entries retain the figures written in the supplied record.

Keane household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 1 June 1900

TWELFTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Sex	Birt h mo.	Birth year	Age	Civil state	Childre n born	Childre n living
Keane, William	Head	M	Oct	1862	37	M	-	-
Keane, Anna	Wife	F	Jul	1867	32	M	-	-
Keane, Nora	Daughter	F	Jan	1900	4/12	-	-	-

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

M = married. Wd = widowed. Ages under one year are recorded in twelfths of a year. The entries retain the figures written in the supplied record.

Reilly household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 1 June 1900

TWELFTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Sex	Birt h mo.	Birth year	Age	Civil state	Childre n born	Childre n living
Reilly, Patrick	Head	M	Apr	1855	45	M	-	-
Reilly, Nora	Wife	F	Aug	1858	41	M	10	10
Reilly, Daniel	Son	M	Jan	1879	21	-	-	-
Reilly, Kathleen	Daughter	F	Jun	1881	18	-	-	-
Reilly, Michael	Son	M	Mar	1883	17	-	-	-
Reilly, Ellen	Daughter	F	Nov	1885	15	-	-	-
Reilly, John	Son	M	Jul	1887	12	-	-	-
Reilly, Margaret	Daughter	F	Sep	1889	10	-	-	-
Reilly, Thomas	Son	M	Dec	1891	8	-	-	-
Reilly, Rose	Daughter	F	May	1894	6	-	-	-
Reilly, Joseph	Son	M	Aug	1897	2	-	-	-
Reilly, Mabel	Daughter	F	Feb	1900	4/12	-	-	-

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

M = married. Wd = widowed. Ages under one year are recorded in twelfths of a year. The entries retain the figures written in the supplied record.

Foster household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 1 June 1900

TWELFTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Sex	Birt h mo.	Birth year	Age	Civil state	Childre n born	Childre n living
Foster, Samuel	Head	M	Nov	1861	38	M	-	-
Foster, Jane	Wife	F	Jun	1866	33	M	-	-
Foster, Ruth	Daughter	F	Apr	1900	1/12	-	-	-

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

M = married. Wd = widowed. Ages under one year are recorded in twelfths of a year. The entries retain the figures written in the supplied record.

Deaths entered in the county

Warren County, Ohio / selected entries, 1900

DEATH REGISTER / 30 AUGUST 1900

Name: Jane Foster

Sex: Female

Date of death: 30 August 1900

Place: Warren County, Ohio

Spouse: Samuel Foster

DEATH REGISTER / 22 SEPTEMBER 1900

Name: Nora Reilly

Sex: Female

Date of death: 22 September 1900

Place: Warren County, Ohio

Spouse: Patrick Reilly

DEATH REGISTER / 19 DECEMBER 1900

Name: Sarah Miller

Sex: Female

Date of death: 19 December 1900

Place: Warren County, Ohio

Spouse: George Miller

Selected identity, date, place, and spouse fields. A cause of death is not supplied in these case extracts.

THE STORY CONTINUES

Four small lives

After BB04-BB09

Mabel copied the four girls' names onto separate lines. At first the task felt almost shameful, as though she were trying on other people's childhoods to see which would fit.

Ruth. Nora. Elsie. Mabel.

Thomas watched her compare the households. "Does one look right?"

"Looking right isn't enough."

She had wanted to answer differently. A familiar given name could feel like recognition before it proved anything. A mother's death could make a terrible story seem complete before she had followed the child beyond it.

Edith read the death entries. "There were three of them."

Three women reduced here to the selected fields of a county register. The extracts did not give a cause. They did not say who put the next meal on the table, who took over the smallest child's washing, or whether the husband accepted help. Those missing scenes pressed into Mabel's mind because she was looking for her own. She had to resist writing them into the evidence.

"A man loses his wife," Thomas began, then stopped.

"And a child loses her mother," Mabel said.

He nodded. "Yes."

Neither sentence settled what happened afterward. Even grief did not make every household do the same thing. The archive held later records. Those children had lives beyond the moment at which this investigation first needed them.

Mabel put the full birth entries beside the index instead of discarding the names that seemed less likely. She wrote event dates separately from dates on newspaper headings. It was slow work, and for once slowness felt like respect.

Edith brought another chair close enough to read over her shoulder. She asked which paper Mabel wanted next. The question was so ordinary that Mabel nearly missed what had changed: her mother was no longer asking why she wanted another paper at all.

They would follow each child as far as the supplied records allowed. Nobody would be chosen merely because her losses made the most affecting explanation.

Bennett household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 15 April 1910

THIRTEENTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Age	Birthplace	Occupation
<i>Bennett, Charles</i>	<i>Head</i>	<i>46</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	<i>farmer</i>
<i>Bennett, Louisa</i>	<i>Wife</i>	<i>43</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Bennett, Arthur</i>	<i>Son</i>	<i>21</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Bennett, Pearl</i>	<i>Daughter</i>	<i>17</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Reilly, Thomas</i>	<i>Boarder</i>	<i>18</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

Doyle household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 15 April 1910

THIRTEENTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Age	Birthplace	Occupation
<i>Doyle, Peter</i>	<i>Head</i>	<i>50</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	<i>farmer</i>
<i>Doyle, Mary</i>	<i>Wife</i>	<i>49</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Doyle, Lucy</i>	<i>Daughter</i>	<i>23</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Doyle, Edward</i>	<i>Son</i>	<i>20</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Doyle, Clara</i>	<i>Daughter</i>	<i>15</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Reilly, Margaret</i>	<i>Niece</i>	<i>20</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

O'Brien household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 15 April 1910

THIRTEENTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Age	Birthplace	Occupation
O'Brien, Jeremiah	Head	47	Ohio	farmer
O'Brien, Agnes	Wife	45	Ohio	-
O'Brien, Francis	Son	22	Ohio	-
O'Brien, Nell	Daughter	19	Ohio	-
Reilly, Rose	Niece	15	Ohio	-

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

Reilly household extract

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 15 April 1910

THIRTEENTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Age	Birthplace	Occupation
Reilly, Patrick	Head	54	Ohio	farmer
Reilly, Michael	Son	27	Ohio	-
Reilly, Ellen	Daughter	24	Ohio	-

CIVIL STATE

Patrick Reilly - Widowed.

Selected residents only. Omission is not proof of death or departure. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

Walsh household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 15 April 1910

THIRTEENTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Age	Birthplace	Occupation
Walsh, Edward	Head	53	Ohio	farmer
Walsh, Helen	Wife	50	Ohio	-
Walsh, Patrick	Son	23	Ohio	-
Walsh, Agnes	Daughter	19	Ohio	-
Reilly, John	Boarder	22	Ohio	Farm laborer

OCCUPATION FIELD

John Reilly - Farm laborer; hired hand.

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

Hale household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 15 April 1910

THIRTEENTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Age	Birthplace	Occupation
Hale, Rebecca	Head	64	Ohio	-
Miller, Elsie	Granddaughter	10	Ohio	-

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

Keane household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 15 April 1910

THIRTEENTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Age	Birthplace	Occupation
Keane, William	Head	47	Ohio	blacksmith
Keane, Anna	Wife	42	Ohio	-
Keane, Nora	Daughter	10	Ohio	-

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.

Departures

Local notice / Wednesday, 1 May 1901

THE WARREN COUNTY CHRONICLE

PERSONAL AND COUNTY ITEMS

Samuel Foster has removed to Indiana, taking with him his daughter Ruth, now a little over a year old. Mrs. Jane Foster died in this county on August 30 of last year.

The notice identifies the child by her given name and her relationship to Samuel Foster. It records a move to Indiana; no town is specified.

Birth-register extracts

Warren County, Ohio / births entered in 1900

26 JANUARY 1900

Child: Nora Keane / female

Born: 26 January 1900 / Warren County, Ohio

Father: William Keane

Mother: Anna Keane

11 FEBRUARY 1900

Child: Mabel Reilly / female

Born: 11 February 1900 / Warren County, Ohio

Father: Patrick Reilly

Mother: Nora Flynn Reilly

3 MARCH 1900

Child: Elsie Miller / female

Born: 3 March 1900 / Warren County, Ohio

Father: George Miller

Mother: Sarah Miller

12 APRIL 1900

Child: Ruth Foster / female

Born: 12 April 1900 / Warren County, Ohio

Father: Samuel Foster

Mother: Jane Foster

Entries are presented in date order. The register records birth identity, not later household placement.

Family marriage extracts

Warren County, Ohio / selected marriage entries

MARRIAGE / 3 JUNE 1878

Groom: Patrick Reilly

Bride: Nora Flynn

Date: 3 June 1878

Place: Warren County, Ohio

MARRIAGE / 11 FEBRUARY 1884

Groom: Peter Doyle

Bride: Mary Flynn

Date: 11 February 1884

Place: Warren County, Ohio

Maiden surnames appear in these marriage extracts. A shared surname alone is not a complete family relationship; compare it with the household evidence.

Church care book

Grace Church / Monday, 1 October 1900

ENTRY CONCERNING THE INFANT FOUND ON SEPTEMBER 30

The female infant found yesterday in the rear pew has this day been received into the care of Thomas and Edith Sutton.

Mr. Sutton is a carpenter of this county. The child is to be taken into their home.

The names of the child's parents remain unknown.

An informal care entry. It is not a court adoption decree and does not identify the person who brought the basket.

THE STORY CONTINUES

A household is not a whole life

After BB10-BB20

The later households would not fit on the same sheet as the earlier ones. Mabel took another page. Thomas offered a larger piece of paper, then waited to see whether she wanted it before clearing the table.

Boarder. Niece. Daughter. Granddaughter.

Each word put someone in relation to the person named at the head of the household. None said whether she liked the room, whether he wrote home, or what it felt like to leave. Mabel could trace the recorded connections without pretending she had recovered all those answers.

"They might have been well cared for," Edith said.

Mabel looked up sharply. "They might have missed someone anyway."

Edith drew a breath. "I know."

Mabel had expected an argument. The absence of one made her hear how much Edith was allowing the sentence to include.

Thomas rested his hands on the back of his chair. He wanted the papers to deliver a person he could blame or thank. Mabel could see the impatience in him because she felt it herself. Somebody had carried a basket. Somebody had walked away. It was easier to picture a face than to accept that the public account did not supply one.

The church care entry was plain about the next day. Thomas and Edith had received the infant into their home. The entry did not turn backward and identify the person from the morning before.

Mabel read it aloud. Her voice was steady until she reached their names.

"We wanted you," Edith said.

"I believe you."

She did not add that this answered everything. Edith did not ask her to.

Mabel made two headings on the work sheet: what the records establish, and what they leave open. Beneath the second she left room. Uncertainty was not the same as having no family. It was a part of this family story that nobody at the table had earned the right to fill by guesswork.

The names still had to be connected, the alternatives tested, the dates counted. After that, there would remain another question: whether understanding a separation would make it feel any less like being left.

Compare the infant identities

Keep a candidate until a record gives you a reason to set her aside.

Start with BB04. Record ages as evidence, not hard cutoffs. Look for a later record for each candidate and compare the date of any family loss with the date of the basket.

Candidate / birth date	Fits the reported age?	Family event / date	Later record / conclusion

WHICH COMPARISON CHANGED YOUR MIND?

Reconstruct a household

Names, relationships, and what happens next

Use this sheet for the family you believe matters most. List the people in its earlier household, then record only the later locations you can actually support. Leave untraced people unresolved.

Earlier name	Relation / birth or age	Later name or household	Record code

WHAT IS THE PATTERN? WHAT IS STILL UNKNOWN?

Build the timeline

Event date comes first; publication dates may differ.

Date	What happened	Who is named	Record code

WHICH INTERVAL MATTERS, AND HOW LONG IS IT?

Six deductions / part one

An answer earns its place through the records you cite.

01 / THE STARTING CONTRADICTION

What is unusual about Mabel's entry in the Sutton household? Which other paper makes this more than a stray census discrepancy?

02 / THE BIRTH IDENTITY

Give Mabel's original full name, date of birth, and biological parents. Cite the birth entry and at least one independent supporting record.

03 / THE TURNING POINT

What happened in the birth family shortly before the child was found? Give both event dates and the elapsed number of days.

Six deductions / part two

A good reconstruction includes the limits of its evidence.

04 / THE HOUSEHOLD PATTERN

How many children were in the earlier birth household? Trace at least three into later households, naming the household and the recorded relationship. What does the pattern support?

05 / THE ALTERNATIVES

For each of the other three infant candidates, cite the later record that supports setting her aside. Explain why an age match or a mother's death is not enough.

06 / THE EXPLANATION AND ITS LIMIT

What circumstances best explain Mabel's arrival at the church? Before the sealed letter, can you identify who physically left the basket? Separate inference from fact.

Make your case

Complete this page before you open the sealed section.

MY CONCLUSION

Mabel Ruth Sutton was born as:

THE THREE STRONGEST RECORDS

Code	What it establishes

ONE UNCERTAINTY THE PAPERS DO NOT RESOLVE

COMMITTED BY / DATE

When you are satisfied with your explanation, open the sealed solution at page 37 or use the separate Sealed Solution PDF. Read the answer key before the private letter. The investigation is complete when you can explain your reasoning, not merely name a family.